Poetry Terms

Concept

Poetry makes meaning through language, sound, rhythm and form. Read aloud, notice patterns, then connect them to an interpretation.

Speaker ≠ poet

The poem's speaking voice may be a created persona.

Sound + meaning

Name the sound pattern and explain its effect in this poem; no sound has one fixed emotion.

Form + meaning

Line breaks, stanza lengths and repetition affect pace and emphasis.

Read in layers

Literal situation → striking details → patterns → possible meaning.

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Example 1 | original model

Original lines: "The tired gate complained / as evening slipped inside."

Solution / why it works

1. Device: personification gives the gate a human action, "complained."
2. Imagery: the gate's sound suggests a creak; evening entering creates a visual scene.
3. Possible effect: tired and complained make the setting feel worn and weary.
4. Avoid overclaiming: the two lines suggest a mood; they do not establish the poet's personal feelings.

Example 2 | original model

Read this rhyme pattern: "We watched the pale and fading light / The river carried leaves away / A lantern trembled in the night / Then darkness folded up the day."

Solution / why it works

1. End words: light / away / night / day.
2. Assign matching sounds: A / B / A / B.
3. This four-line stanza is a quatrain with an ABAB rhyme scheme.

Poetry Terms

Reference | Poem types

Poem

Language organized for concentrated effects of meaning, sound, rhythm or visual form.

Speaker

The voice within a poem; do not automatically identify it with the poet.

Ballad

A narrative poem or song, often using repetition and a regular stanza pattern; it need not be tragic.

Concrete poetry

The arrangement of letters and words contributes visually to meaning.

Dramatic monologue

A single speaker reveals character and situation while addressing an implied listener.

Elegy

A poem of mourning, loss or remembrance.

Epic

An extended narrative poem, often about consequential actions or a community's history.

Epitaph

A short inscription or poem commemorating someone who has died.

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Epigram

A brief, pointed, often witty statement or poem.

Free verse

Poetry without a required regular metrical or rhyme scheme; patterns may still occur.

Lyric

Usually a relatively short poem expressing perception, thought or feeling.

Narrative poem

A poem that tells a story.

Parody

An imitation of another work or style for comic or critical effect.

Pastoral

Writing that represents rural life, often in an idealized way.

Sonnet

Traditionally a 14-line poem; English sonnets commonly use iambic pentameter and structured rhyme.

Ode

A lyric that addresses, celebrates or thoughtfully considers a subject.

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Reference | Sound

Alliteration

Repetition of initial consonant sounds in nearby words: wild winter winds.

Assonance

Repetition of vowel sounds in nearby words: slow road home.

Consonance

Repetition of consonant sounds, not restricted to word beginnings or middles: blank and think share /nk/.

Cacophony

A harsh or jarring combination of sounds; the effect depends on context.

Dissonance

Discordant or clashing sounds that disturb smoothness.

Euphony

A pleasing or flowing combination of sounds.

Onomatopoeia

A word imitates a sound: hiss, buzz or clang. Also called imitative harmony.

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Reference | Comparison & figurative language

Metaphor

A non-literal comparison that presents one thing as another: the city is a maze.

Extended metaphor

A comparison developed over several lines or a whole work.

Simile

A comparison using like or as: the street curled like a ribbon.

Personification

Human qualities given to something non-human: the window sighed.

Metonymy

A related thing stands for another: the crown for royal authority.

Synecdoche

A part stands for the whole, or the whole for a part: hands for workers.

Figurative / literal language

Figurative meaning goes beyond ordinary literal sense; literal wording states what it directly means.

Hyperbole / understatement

Deliberate exaggeration / deliberate reduction of apparent importance.

Oxymoron

Seemingly contradictory terms placed together: deafening silence.

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Paradox

An apparently contradictory statement that invites a deeper interpretation; not merely a longer oxymoron.

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Reference | Word choice & meaning

Allusion

A reference to another work, person, event, place or tradition.

Apostrophe

Direct address to an absent person, an abstraction or something non-human.

Cliché

An expression or idea weakened by overuse.

Connotation / denotation

Associated feelings or ideas / the direct dictionary meaning.

Euphemism

A milder or indirect expression replaces a harsh or uncomfortable one.

Idiom

An established expression whose meaning is not simply the literal meaning of its words.

Image / imagery

A sensory detail / the use or pattern of sensory details, involving any of the five senses.

Mood

The atmosphere or feeling the poem creates.

Tone

The speaker's attitude toward the subject or audience.

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Voice

The distinctive personality or qualities of the speaking or writing style.

Symbol

Something signifies beyond itself; establish that meaning through context.

Repetition

Deliberately repeated sounds, words, phrases or lines.

Syntax

The arrangement of words, phrases and clauses.

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Reference | Verse forms, metre & rhyme

Stanza / verse paragraph

A group of lines functioning as a unit; rhyme is not required.

Couplet / quatrain

A pair of lines / a four-line stanza; often rhymed, but not necessarily.

Sestet / octave

A six-line unit / an eight-line unit, especially parts of a sonnet.

Ballad stanza

Often four lines alternating four and three metrical feet, with ABCB or ABAB rhyme. Variations occur.

Blank verse

Unrhymed metrical verse, typically iambic pentameter. A rhyming sonnet is not blank verse.

Rhythm / metre

Rhythm is the movement of sound; metre is an organizing pattern of stresses.

Iamb

A metrical foot with an unstressed then stressed syllable: de-LIGHT.

Iambic pentameter

Five iambic feet per line; ten syllables is typical, but actual lines can vary.

Trimeter / tetrameter

Three / four metrical feet per line.

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Other metre lengths

Dimeter: 2; pentameter: 5; hexameter: 6; heptameter: 7; octameter: 8 feet.

Rhyme

Correspondence of sounds, usually from the last stressed vowel onward.

End rhyme / internal rhyme

Rhyme at line endings / rhyme within a line.

Rhyme scheme

Letters mark matching end sounds, starting with A.

Refrain

A repeated line or group of lines.

English sonnet pattern

ABAB CDCD EFEF GG: three quatrains and a closing couplet.

Petrarchan sonnet pattern

An octave, often ABBAABBA, followed by a sestet such as CDECDE or CDCDCD.

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Quick checks | avoid common mix-ups

Blank verse ≠ sonnet

Blank verse does not rhyme. Traditional sonnets have rhyme schemes. The original handout incorrectly groups all sonnets with blank verse.

Stanza size ≠ rhyme

Couplet, quatrain, sestet and octave identify line groupings; these groupings do not always have to rhyme.

Consonance

Repeated consonant sounds can occur in different word positions, not only the middle.

Poem types can overlap

A poem can be both lyric and elegy, or narrative and ballad. The original decision tree is a rough classroom guide, not an exhaustive classification.

Interpretation needs evidence

Identify the speaker's situation and the details supporting your reading. A title or one word alone may not settle the meaning.

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Practice | your turn

1. Name the device: "The wind whispered through the wire." Explain two possible sound patterns.

2. Write a two-line metaphor and extend the same comparison in a third line.

3. Explain the difference between blank verse and free verse.

4. Write a tone word and a mood word for a poem, then justify each with a detail.

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Sample answers | check after trying

Writing tasks can have more than one strong answer. Use these models and checks to review your work.

1

Personification: wind whispers. Alliteration: repeated initial /w/ sounds in wind, whispered and wire.

2

Keep the comparison coherent. Example: The city is a notebook; its streets are lines; each traveller leaves a sentence.

3

Blank verse has metre (usually iambic pentameter) without rhyme. Free verse has no required regular metrical or rhyme scheme.

4

Tone describes the speaker's attitude; mood describes the atmosphere or feeling created.

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Source & editing note

Poetry 12 Terms1.pdf | 8 supplied pages.

No author identified in the supplied handout. Concepts reorganized and condensed; repeated templates consolidated. Examples, practice and sample answers here are original additions, not copied student work.

Historical exam asterisks and "new term" markers were omitted; they do not establish current course or exam requirements. Definitions were clarified where the handout oversimplified them.

Definition check: Academy of American Poets | blank verse

Definition check: Poetry Foundation | sonnet